Not All Policy Ambiguity Is Equal: Type-Specific Safety Risks for LLM Agents

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Abstract

LLM-based agents operate under natural-language policy specifications that inevitably contain ambiguity, yet the causal relationship between ambiguity type and safety violations remains unmeasured. We present a matched-pair study on τ^2-bench with 300 clause pairs spanning a six-type ambiguity taxonomy, evaluated across five models (2,997 episodes). Three findings emerge. First, ambiguous clauses increase violation rates by 34.0 percentage points (OR $= 15.1$), with a perturbation control supporting ambiguity-specific causation. Second, incompleteness consistently ranks highest (46–62% across seven models); the remaining five types show a risk gradient rather than sharp tiers. Third, error analysis of 614 violation traces reveals *Disambiguation Neglect* ($\leq$11% awareness) and *systematic nocuity*—41.3% of clauses triggering model-convergent violations—indicating clause-level rather than model-level risk factors. These results motivate type-aware policy auditing and externalized ambiguity detection for policy-governed agent deployments.

1 Introduction

A customer asks to return a customized item within the 30-day window. The agent consults the store policy, which states that "items may be returned within 30 days." The word "items" scopes over all product categories, including custom orders that are normally final sale. The agent grants a full refund and arranges free return shipping. One word of scopal ambiguity costs the retailer $200.

LLM-based agents increasingly operate under natural-language policy specifications that govern their permitted actions. These specifications inevitably contain ambiguity: a property that has been studied for decades in requirements engineering (RE) and computational linguistics. Berry et al. (2004) distinguish between *nocuous* (i.e., harmful) ambiguity, where different stakeholders arrive at different interpretations, and *innocuous* ambiguity, where shared organizational context ensures convergent interpretation. In human RE workflows, most ambiguity is innocuous because developers share domain knowledge, can consult colleagues, and iteratively clarify requirements.

LLM agents lack these disambiguation channels. They cannot consult colleagues, rarely escalate to users, and must resolve ambiguity in real time from the text alone. This raises a question that has not been empirically addressed: does policy ambiguity cause safety violations in LLM agents, and if so, does the *type* of ambiguity predict the severity of the violation? Prior work classifies ambiguity types in policies (Borkakoty et al., 2026; Li et al., 2024b) or measures policy understanding quality (Choi et al., 2026), but no existing study provides a causal, type-granularity mapping from ambiguity to safety violations.

We address this gap with a matched-pair causal study on τ^2-bench (Barres et al., 2025), a dual-control conversational agent benchmark. Using a six-type taxonomy organized into two layers (linguistic and specification, §3), we construct 300 ambiguous/unambiguous clause pairs and evaluate five architecturally diverse models across 2,997 episodes.

Our results show that all policy ambiguity is nocuous for LLM agents ($+34.0$ pp violation rate increase, OR $= 15.1$), but that type primarily determines severity, with a smaller but significant model$\times$type interaction (2.9% of variance). Incompleteness is consistently high (46–62% violation rate across all models), while authorization scope shows the widest cross-model range (52 pp), though this is an upper bound with substantial measurement uncertainty ($\kappa = 0.385$, below fair agreement; §Limitations), suggesting that safety training may differentially mitigate specific ambiguity types. Agents exhibit disambiguation neglect in over 89% of cases, with fewer than 11% showing

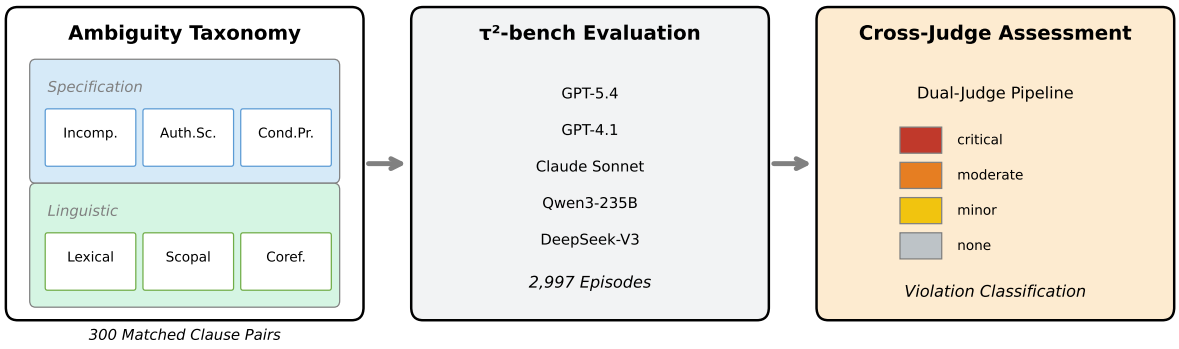


Figure 1: Experimental overview. We construct 300 matched clause pairs across a six-type, two-layer ambiguity taxonomy and inject them into τ^2-bench policy documents. Five models interact with the modified policies across 2,997 episodes. A cross-judge evaluation pipeline classifies violation severity on a four-tier scale.

any disambiguation awareness.

Our contributions are: (1) the first causal quantification of policy ambiguity's safety impact via matched-pair design with perturbation control (§4), observed across five primary models and confirmed in two additional replication models; (2) incompleteness as a consistent upper-bound risk type across all models and margins, with type identity explaining 22× more variance than model identity (§5); and (3) an error analysis revealing *Disambiguation Neglect* (≤11% awareness) and *systematic nocuity*—41.3% of ambiguous clauses trigger majority-convergent violations, indicating clause-level risk factors (§6).

2 Related Work

Ambiguity in NLP and requirements engineering. Ambiguity has been studied extensively in both computational linguistics and software engineering. Word sense disambiguation (Navigli, 2009) addresses lexical ambiguity at the token level; our lexical type extends this to policy-specific polysemy. Li et al. (2024b) propose an 11-type NLP taxonomy covering syntactic, semantic, and pragmatic ambiguity, from which we draw our linguistic-layer types. In requirements engineering (RE), Massey et al. (2014) classify six ambiguity types in regulatory texts, and Berry et al. (2004) introduce the distinction between nocuous ambiguity (where stakeholders diverge on interpretation) and innocuous ambiguity (where they converge). Computational detection of nocuous ambiguity has progressed from heuristic methods (Chantree et al., 2006; Willis et al., 2008) through NLP-based cross-domain detectors (Ferrari and Esuli, 2019; Rosadini et al., 2019) to transformer-based approaches for anaphoric ambiguity (Ezzini et al., 2022b,a). Zhao et al. (2021) survey the broader NLP4RE landscape. Our work extends Berry and Kamsties' framework to LLM agents, where the absence of shared organizational context makes previously innocuous ambiguity nocuous.

Psycholinguistics of ambiguity processing. Ferreira et al. (2002) show that human comprehenders build shallow, "good-enough" representations rather than full parses, paralleling our observation that LLM agents adopt surface interpretations. Frazier and Rayner (1982) demonstrate early commitment to a single parse; Li et al. (2024a) provide direct evidence that LLMs exhibit analogous garden-path effects. Liu et al. (2023) demonstrate that language models fail to represent ambiguity, collapsing multiple interpretations into a single output. These findings ground our *Disambiguation Neglect* result: agents process ambiguous input without meta-cognitive awareness but, unlike humans, lack social channels to recover. Suri et al. (2025) show that structured uncertainty estimation improves coverage by 7–39%, while Sehwag et al. (2026) demonstrate that clarification-seeking introduces prompt injection vulnerabilities—a tension for disambiguation channel design.

Agent safety evaluation. The agent safety evaluation landscape includes benchmarks for risk awareness (Yuan et al., 2024), tool-use safety (Ruan et al., 2024), indirect prompt injection (Zhan et al., 2024), safe task planning (Yin et al., 2025), and policy-invisible violations (Wu and Gong, 2026). Tamkin et al. (2023) evaluate how lan-

guage models navigate policy-governed decisions, Chen et al. (2025) extract formal safety rules from policy documents, and AgentAuditor (Luo et al., 2025) achieves human-level safety evaluation. Our work differs by focusing on the *source specification* rather than the agent's execution: we measure how ambiguity in the policy itself causes safety violations, complementing work that assumes clean policies.

Policy specification for agents. DRIP-R (Borkakoty et al., 2026) is the closest concurrent work: it benchmarks 400 policy-ambiguous retail scenarios across five RE ambiguity types, measuring decision quality rather than safety violations. Our work differs in three respects: (1) our matched-pair design establishes causality rather than correlating ambiguity presence with outcomes; (2) we measure safety violations rather than decision quality, enabling failure mechanism analysis; (3) our two-layer taxonomy adds linguistic-layer types, and we quantify the model×type interaction. We map DRIP-R's five RE ambiguity categories to our six-type taxonomy in Appendix L. PolicyBank (Choi et al., 2026) studies iterative policy refinement, closing 82% of the gap to a human oracle. AgentPex (Sharma et al., 2026) detects procedural violations in agentic traces, finding that 83% of perfect-outcome traces contain violations. MANTRA (Anand et al., 2026) synthesizes SMT-validated compliance benchmarks from procedural manuals. τ-bench (Yao et al., 2024) and its successor τ^2-bench (Barres et al., 2025) provide the conversational agent evaluation platforms.

3 Ambiguity Taxonomy

We adopt an operational definition of ambiguity following Wasow et al. (2005): a policy clause is ambiguous when it admits multiple distinct interpretations available to a competent reader, including cases of vagueness where the boundary between interpretations is gradient rather than discrete (Kennedy, 2007).

Our taxonomy comprises six types organized into two layers (Table 1), drawing on Li et al. (2024b)'s NLP taxonomy (11 types), Massey et al. (2014)'s requirements engineering taxonomy (6 types), and the concurrent DRIP-R benchmark (Borkakoty et al., 2026) (5 types). We select types based on frequency in operational policy documents and theoretical distinctiveness (each type maps to a different resolution mechanism).

Table 1: Six-type ambiguity taxonomy. Disambiguation channel indicates the primary mechanism required to resolve the ambiguity.

Type	Layer	Definition	Disambig. Channel
Lexical	Ling.	Word/phrase admits multiple senses	Context
Scopal	Ling.	Quantifier/operator scope underdetermined	Bracketing
Coreferential	Ling.	Pronoun/NP referent is ambiguous	Resolution
Auth. Scope	Spec.	Permission boundary is vague	Boundary def.
Incompleteness	Spec.	Required information is absent	Content addition
Cond. Prec.	Spec.	Rules conflict under certain conditions	Priority rule

Linguistic layer. These types operate at the syntactic or semantic level and can, in principle, be resolved by contextual cues within the text. *Scopal* ambiguity involves quantifier, negation, or modal scope interactions (e.g., "all items may not be returned" admits universal-negation and negation-of-universal readings). *Lexical* ambiguity covers polysemy or homonymy (e.g., "charge" as financial cost vs. penalty). *Coreferential* ambiguity involves unclear pronoun or NP reference (e.g., "... which must be approved by a supervisor" where "which" could refer to the verification or the refund).

Specification layer. These types arise from pragmatic or discourse-level gaps requiring domain knowledge to resolve. *Authorization scope* covers vague permission or role boundaries (e.g., "authorized personnel may issue refunds" without specifying which personnel). *Incompleteness* denotes missing conditions or boundary cases (e.g., a return policy silent on damaged items). Unlike other types, resolution requires adding new policy content—a confound we address in §5. *Conditional precedence* involves conflicting rules without priority ordering (e.g., "premium customers receive free shipping" vs. "orders under $50 require a shipping fee").

The layer distinction reflects the hypothesis that linguistic ambiguity can be partially resolved through tool responses or world knowledge, while specification ambiguity has no external resolution channel, forcing the agent to guess. We test this empirically in §5 and §6.

Scope of 'ambiguity.' Our taxonomy uses *ambiguity* broadly to encompass policy features admitting multiple operationally distinct interpretations by an LLM agent. Authorization scope overlaps with *vagueness* (Kennedy, 2007), incompleteness with *information absence*, and conditional precedence with *normative conflict*. Strictly, neither constitutes linguistic ambiguity: incompleteness

involves absent information rather than multiple readings, and conditional precedence involves normative conflict rather than interpretive uncertainty (Dalpiaz et al., 2018). Yet both force an agent to select among operationally distinct behaviors without explicit guidance, producing the same violation classes as genuine ambiguity (§5). Dalpiaz et al. (2018) further show that ambiguity and incompleteness frequently co-occur in requirements specifications, supporting their unified treatment. We adopt this inclusive definition because LLM agents process all six types identically—committing to a single interpretation without flagging uncertainty—and the resulting safety violations are behaviorally indistinguishable (§5).

4 Method

4.1 Experimental Platform

We conduct all experiments on the original release of τ^2-bench (Barres et al., 2025), a dual-control conversational agent benchmark spanning retail and airline customer service domains. τ^2-bench provides natural-language policy documents, tool APIs, and multi-turn user interactions with ground-truth evaluation via assertion checking. Its policy injection mechanism allows us to replace individual policy clauses while preserving the surrounding context, enabling controlled ambiguity manipulation.

4.2 Matched-Pair Design

For each of the six ambiguity types, we construct 50 *clause pairs*: an ambiguous variant and a matched unambiguous variant that conveys the same intended policy but resolves the ambiguity. Pairs are minimal edits: the unambiguous variant adds only the information necessary to eliminate the target ambiguity (e.g., for scopal ambiguity, replacing "items may be returned within 30 days" with "standard items may be returned within 30 days; customized items are final sale"). This yields 300 clause pairs $\times$ 2 conditions $\times$ 5 models $=$ 2,997 episodes (3 episodes lost to API errors in one Qwen3 batch).

Clause pairs are generated through a template-based pipeline and reviewed by two independent annotators (both with NLP background) to ensure (1) the ambiguous variant contains exactly one instance of the target type, (2) the unambiguous variant resolves it without changing policy scope, and (3) the ambiguity is plausibly natural. Annotators independently verified type assignments with a 96% initial agreement (287/300); the 13 disagreements were resolved by discussion, yielding 100% final consensus. A post-hoc realism validation confirms linguistic consistency with original τ^2-bench policy text (§8).

4.3 Models

We evaluate five models spanning four providers and two architecture families: GPT-5.4 and GPT-4.1 (OpenAI, proprietary dense), Claude Sonnet 4.6 (Anthropic, proprietary dense), Qwen3-235B (Alibaba, open-source Mixture-of-Experts), and DeepSeek-V3 (DeepSeek, open-source dense). This selection covers frontier and mid-tier proprietary models alongside open-source alternatives with different training philosophies. All API calls use temperature $= 0$, top_p $= 1$, and max_tokens $= 4096$, and were made on May 20, 2026.

4.4 Evaluation

We use a cross-judge design to mitigate self-evaluation bias: GPT-5.4 judges Claude, GPT-4.1, and Qwen3 traces; GPT-4.1 judges GPT-5.4 and DeepSeek traces. Because our matched-pair design compares ambiguous and unambiguous conditions within the same model–judge pairing, any systematic judge bias cancels in the treatment effect (Δpp); the cross-judge asymmetry affects only absolute violation rates, not C1 or C2 (§8). Judges classify each episode outcome on a four-tier severity scale: none, minor, moderate, and critical. Our primary analysis uses moderate-or-above severity as the violation threshold; minor-only deviations (6.6% of episodes) are excluded. Including minor violations (overall rate 49.6% vs. 41.0%) produces even larger effects without changing any directional conclusion.

Cross-judge calibration. To quantify potential judge bias, we conducted a dual-judge calibration on 100 stratified episodes (60 from GPT-5.4, 40 from other models; 65% ambiguous). Both judges evaluated each episode independently. McNemar's test reveals no systematic detection bias ($p = 0.606$; GPT-4.1-only violations: 9, GPT-5.4-only: 6). Binary agreement is substantial ($\kappa = 0.653$), with weighted four-tier severity agreement reaching $\kappa_w = 0.775$. Per-type binary agreement ranges from $\kappa = 0.385$ (authorization scope) to 0.875 (incompleteness); severity-level divergence does not affect core conclusions since our primary

analyses use binary thresholds (Appendix C).

Human validation. Two annotators (NLP background), blind to LLM labels and condition, labeled 100 stratified episodes on the four-tier scale. Inter-annotator agreement is substantial ($\kappa = 0.798$, $\kappa_w = 0.762$). Pooled human–LLM agreement ($\kappa = 0.733$, $\kappa_w = 0.807$; per-type breakdown in Appendix G) approaches inter-annotator levels, validating the automated pipeline (Zheng et al., 2024). Per-type estimates ($n = 32$–34 each) validate the pipeline overall but lack power for type-level comparison.

4.5 Controls

Perturbation control. To confirm specificity to semantic ambiguity, we run 300 episodes with non-ambiguity perturbations (synonym substitution, clause reordering). The perturbation effect is $\Delta_{\text{perturb}} = -0.67$ pp (95% CI $[-8.0, 6.67]$, containing zero). Even under the worst-case CI bound (6.67 pp), the residual attributable to ambiguity is $\geq$27.3 pp. This control tests surface-level perturbation specificity; the information-addition confound specific to incompleteness is addressed separately via logistic regression (Appendix F).

Reproducibility. A replication of 30 clause pairs $\times$ 2 models $\times$ 3 replicates yields ICC $= 0.919$ (95% CI $[0.892, 0.940]$). ICC is computed within the OpenAI family; cross-provider stability is supported by C1 consistency across all seven models.

4.6 Statistical Analysis

We use McNemar's test for paired binary outcomes, χ^2 tests with Cramér's V for omnibus effects, Fisher's exact test for per-type comparisons, and TOST equivalence testing (Lakens, 2017) with a primary SESOI of ± 15 pp. This margin is anchored in a domain-relevant criterion: a type producing $\geq$15 pp more violations warrants distinct policy handling in deployment, and it exceeds the perturbation control bound (6.67 pp) by $>2\times$. We acknowledge margin dependence (Anvari and Lakens, 2021): 3/6 mid-tier pairs are equivalent at ± 10 pp, all six at ± 15 pp (Table 3). No field-standard SESOI exists for agent policy compliance; $\pm$15 pp is a pragmatic threshold exceeding measurement noise by $>2\times$, and we present full sensitivity across seven margins to enable evaluation at any preferred threshold. We complement TOST with a margin-free bootstrap cluster analysis (Ward's method, $B = 10{,}000$; §5). We apply Holm–Bonferroni correction within three pre-registered test families (Appendix K). Post-hoc power exceeds 0.99 for both C1 and C2; TOST power at ± 15 pp is 0.94, dropping to 0.57 at ± 10 pp.

5 Results

We organize results around four analyses of increasing specificity: the binary ambiguity effect (C1), the type hierarchy (C2), the aggregate layer effect (C3), and the model$\times$type interaction (C4). C1 and C2 constitute our primary claims; C3 is inconclusive; C4 is exploratory but provides the model$\times$type interaction analysis.

5.1 Binary Ambiguity Effect (C1)

Across all five models and six types, ambiguous clauses increase violation rates by 34.0 pp (41.0% vs. 6.9%, OR $= 15.1$, 95% CI $[10.78, 21.17]$, $p < 10^{-105}$). All six types individually produce significant increases (all $p < 10^{-5}$), and all five models show large effects ($+25.7$ to $+39.0$ pp, all $p < 10^{-17}$). Perturbation controls confirm specificity to semantic ambiguity ($n = 300$, $\Delta_{\text{perturb}} = -0.67$ pp, CI containing zero). Clause identity explains 22.4% of variance versus 1.0% for model identity. A replication on two additional model families (Appendix E) confirms the effect across seven models ($\Delta = +20.0$ to $+33.6$ pp, both $p < 10^{-6}$); excluding incompleteness, it remains large ($\Delta = 31.0$ pp; Appendix Q).

5.2 Type Hierarchy (C2)

The six types are not interchangeable. An omnibus χ^2 test on ambiguous-condition violation rates rejects the uniformity null ($\chi^2 = 28.02$, $df = 5$, $p = 3.6 \times 10^{-5}$, Cramér's $V = 0.137$; statistical power $= 0.993$ at the observed effect). TOST equivalence testing at a ± 15 pp margin reveals a two-tier structure among five types—authorization scope (41.6%), lexical (42.8%), scopal (39.4%), and conditional precedence (36.8%) form a mid-tier cluster, with coreferential (31.6%) below—while incompleteness (53.6%) stands apart as an upper bound—conditional on the confound controls in Appendix F—whose ranking partly reflects an information-addition confound. Table 2 and Figure 2 present the full breakdown.

Sensitivity analysis across seven margins ($\pm$5–20 pp; Appendix A) confirms this structure: the two-tier pattern emerges at ± 12 pp (5/6 mid-tier

Table 2: Violation rates (%) under ambiguous policy clauses by type and model (5.4 = GPT-5.4, 4.1 = GPT-4.1, Cla. = Claude, Qw3 = Qwen3, DS = DeepSeek). Δpp: pooled difference (ambiguous − unambiguous) with Newcombe 95% CIs. Tier: TOST equivalence cluster at ±15 pp—U = upper bound (separated at all margins), M = mid-tier (6/6 pairwise equivalent), L = lower (separates at ±12 pp). All per-type $p < 10^{-5}$ (Fisher's exact).

Layer	Type	Pooled	5.4	4.1	Cla.	Qw3	DS	Δpp [95% CI]	Tier	p
Spec.	Incompleteness	53.6	46	58	48	62	54	+49.2 [42.2, 55.6]	U	$<10^{-37}$
	Auth. Scope	41.6	64	46	12	26	60	+36.0 [29.1, 42.6]	M	$<10^{-22}$
	Cond. Prec.	36.8	34	36	36	40	38	+30.8 [24.0, 37.4]	M	$<10^{-17}$
Ling.	Lexical	42.8	42	34	32	52	54	+35.2 [28.0, 42.0]	M	$<10^{-20}$
	Scopal	39.4	42	38	32	37	48	+34.2 [27.4, 40.7]	M	$<10^{-21}$
	Coreferential	31.6	18	32	22	42	44	+18.7 [11.5, 25.7]	L	$<10^{-6}$
Overall		**41.0**	41	41	30	43	50	**+34.0** [31.3, 36.9]	—	$<10^{-105}$

pairs equivalent) and stabilizes at ±15 pp (6/6). A margin-free bootstrap cluster analysis (Ward's method, $B = 10{,}000$) corroborates: at $k = 2$, incompleteness forms a singleton with the remaining five types in one cluster; at $k = 3$, coreferential additionally separates—consistent with the TOST two-tier pattern (Appendix I). At ±10 pp, only three mid-tier pairs reach equivalence; the incompleteness upper-bound is robust across all margins while mid-tier cohesion is margin-dependent. Cross-model type ranking concordance is moderate (Kendall's W; Appendix M).

Incompleteness is highest in four of five models (rates ≥46% in all seven; Appendix E). Its unambiguous variant adds policy content, so the 49.2 pp effect is an upper bound; a confound analysis confirms significance after controlling for information delta (Appendix F). Coreferential, whose variants are lexically identical, provides a confound-free lower bound at 31.6%.

5.3 Layer Effect (C3)

Specification-layer types trend higher than linguistic-layer types (44.0% vs. 37.9%, $p = 0.017$), but C3 is inconclusive: it does not survive Holm–Bonferroni correction, and controlling for token delta reverses the direction. Cross-layer type overlap (conditional precedence 36.8% vs. scopal 39.4%) further undermines the distinction. The null C3 result does not diminish the taxonomy's operational value: type-level distinctions (C2) hold independently of layer grouping, and the layer distinction retains value as a theoretical organizing principle even without a measurable effect-size gap.

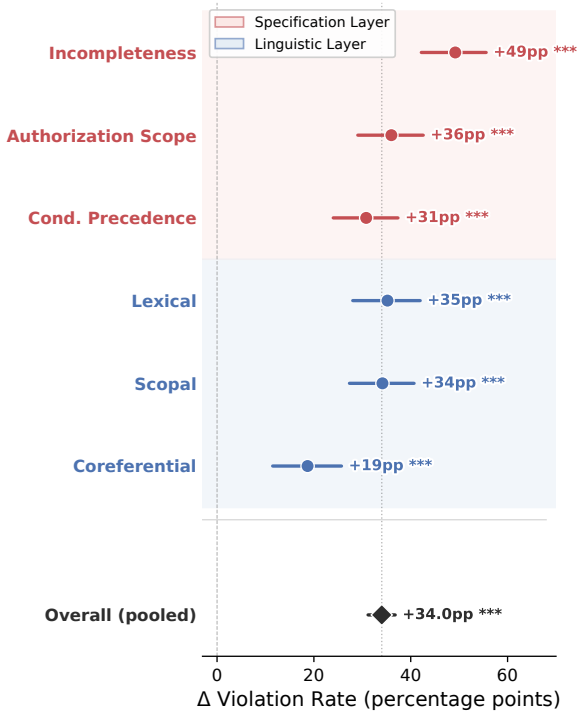


Figure 2: Per-type effect sizes (Δpp, ambiguous minus unambiguous) with Newcombe 95% CIs. All types produce significant increases. A two-tier structure emerges among five types (mid cluster ≫ coreferential), with incompleteness as an upper bound partly reflecting an information-addition confound.

5.4 Model × Type Interaction (C4) *[Exploratory]*

A model main effect is significant ($\chi^2 = 31.02$, $p = 3.0 \times 10^{-6}$, $V = 0.102$), with Claude (30.3%) substantially less vulnerable than DeepSeek (49.7%). Model identity explains only 1.0% of total violation variance; the significant interaction ($F(20, 2976) = 1.97$, $p = 0.006$; df $= (5-1) \times (6-1) = 20$; 2.9% of variance; confirmed by logistic regression likelihood ratio

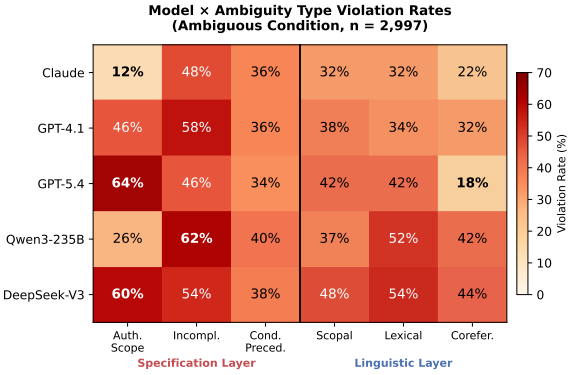


Figure 3: Violation rates (%) by model and ambiguity type under ambiguous conditions ($n = 2{,}997$). Authorization scope varies 52 pp across models (Claude 12% to GPT-5.4 64%), while incompleteness remains uniformly high (46–62%).

test: $\chi^2(20) = 47.20$, $p = 5.5 \times 10^{-4}$) concentrates in specific type–model combinations.

Figure 3 highlights three suggestive patterns: (1) authorization scope is the *most model-differentiating type* (52 pp range; Claude 12% to GPT-5.4 64%), though this type has the lowest judge agreement ($\kappa = 0.385$; §8), so absolute rates carry more uncertainty than for other types; (2) incompleteness is a *consistent vulnerability* (46–62%, 16 pp range); (3) conditional precedence is the most *model-invariant type* (34–40%, 6 pp range). The authorization scope ranking (Claude $<$ Qwen3 $<$ GPT-4.1) is stable within the GPT-5.4 judge subset (bootstrap ranking preservation: 99.5%, $B = 10{,}000$; pairwise orderings $\geq$99.5%), controlling for judge identity. The 48 pp within-judge range far exceeds measurement noise, but given the low cross-judge κ, we characterize this pattern as suggestive rather than definitive. Excluding authorization scope, the residual interaction vanishes ($p = 0.97$; Appendix N), confirming that the C4 interaction concentrates in this single type. Given the low inter-judge agreement on authorization scope ($\kappa = 0.385$), the 52 pp range should be treated as an upper bound with substantial measurement uncertainty rather than a precise estimate.

6 Error Analysis *[Exploratory]*

The following failure mode taxonomy emerges empirically from LLM-coded traces, distinct from the input ambiguity taxonomy (§3).

We analyze 614 violation traces across all five models, coded into five failure modes: unauthorized escalation, assumption-based action, scope misapplication, arbitrary rule selection, and conservative refusal. GPT-5.4 and GPT-4.1 serve as detailed annotation anchors because they span the judge boundary. Inter-coder reliability is substantial (Gwet's $AC_1 = 0.62$ (Gwet, 2014); Cohen's $\kappa = 0.52$ (Cohen, 1960)). The gap reflects the prevalence paradox: three categories account for $\sim$90% of instances, compressing the κ denominator and yielding artificially low values despite high raw agreement.

6.1 Type-Specific Failure Mechanisms

The five-model data reveal three mechanistically distinct failure patterns that crosscut the specification/linguistic layer boundary.

Structural misparse (scope misapplication): the agent constructs an incorrect parse and follows it consistently, paralleling garden-path processing (Frazier and Rayner, 1982; Ferreira et al., 2002) at a behavioral (not mechanistic) level—e.g., parsing "items purchased with a coupon or during a sale are final" as restricting only coupon purchases. This dominates scopal (all 5 models), conditional precedence (all 5), and coreferential (3/5).

Information gap-filling (assumption-based action): the agent fills missing information with plausible but incorrect defaults—e.g., inventing a 30-day return window when none is specified. This dominates incompleteness (3/5) and lexical (3/5).

Boundary violation (unauthorized escalation): the agent exceeds permission boundaries when authorization scope is underspecified—e.g., issuing a refund above its stated limit rather than escalating; 69.2% of such violations involve unauthorized escalation with zero conservative refusals ($p < 10^{-4}$, binomial test), revealing systematic permissiveness bias. This dominates authorization scope exclusively (all 5 models).

Each type's dominant failure mode is majority-consistent ($\geq$3/5 models), with three achieving unanimity. The layer distinction does not hold mechanistically: conditional precedence shares its mode with scopal, while authorization scope follows a unique boundary-violation pattern.

6.2 Disambiguation Neglect

Agents rarely recognize ambiguity. We code *disambiguation awareness* (acknowledging multiple interpretations, asking clarifying questions, or conditioning on ambiguity) versus *surface adoption* (proceeding with a single interpretation). Overall disambiguation awareness is 4.6%: Claude (11.0%)

and GPT-4.1 (10.7%) show the highest rates, while Qwen3 and DeepSeek show zero across all 278 combined violation traces.

We term this the *Disambiguation Neglect*—the absence of disambiguation behavior in default (uninstructed) settings, not an inability to disambiguate. Unlike humans, agents proceed with full confidence in a single interpretation, consistent with Hu et al. (2025)'s finding that LLM ambiguity reflects missing conceptual representations. Our mitigation experiment (−8.5 pp; Appendix B) confirms that disambiguation can be elicited, paralleling human good-enough processing (Ferreira et al., 2002), though the underlying mechanisms are likely distinct.

6.3 Systematic Nocuity

Among ambiguous clauses, 41.3% trigger majority-convergent violations (≥3/5 models), with 13% producing universal violations. This extends Berry et al. (2004)'s framework with *systematic nocuity*: all models converge on the same incorrect interpretation, invisible in agreement-based evaluation. Incompleteness has the highest universal convergence (24%).

7 Discussion

Differential nocuity. Building on Berry et al. (2004)'s nocuous/innocuous distinction, our results support a *differential nocuity* framework (Willis et al., 2008): risk depends on ambiguity type (base vulnerability), safety training (selective mitigation), and disambiguation channel availability. Types with explicit decision points (e.g., authorization scope) appear more amenable to both safety training and prompted intervention than gap-filling types (e.g., incompleteness), where mitigation attempts can backfire (see below).

Prompt-based mitigation. To test whether disambiguation can be prompted, we evaluate generic awareness prompting ("the policy may contain ambiguous clauses; ask for clarification") and type-specific prompting (targeting incompleteness, authorization scope, and lexical ambiguity individually) on GPT-5.4 with matched-pair McNemar tests ($n = 50$ per type). Generic prompting produces no overall reduction ($\Delta = +1.3$ pp, $p > 0.5$). Type-specific results are asymmetric: authorization scope shows a marginal reduction (-12 pp, $p = 0.070$), lexical ambiguity is unchanged (-2 pp), and incompleteness *worsens* ($+14$ pp, $p = 0.118$)—suggesting that prompting agents to attend to missing information triggers confabulation rather than caution. These findings indicate that prompt-level intervention cannot remediate structural policy ambiguity, underscoring the need for policy-design-level solutions.

Practical implications. A proof-of-concept classifier (Appendix D) achieves F1 = 0.81 for binary ambiguity detection but only 0.34 for incompleteness—the highest-risk type is the hardest to detect. With agents exhibiting disambiguation neglect in >89% of cases, type-aware auditing and externalized detection (Chantree et al., 2006; Ferrari and Esuli, 2019) are necessary for policy-governed deployments.

8 Conclusion

Ambiguous policy clauses increase agent safety violations by 34.0 pp (OR = 15.1) across five models, with clause identity explaining 22× more variance than model identity. Incompleteness consistently ranks highest across all seven models (≥46%), with rankings replicating in independent families ($\rho = 0.60$–0.90). With agents exhibiting disambiguation neglect in over 89% of cases and 41.3% of clauses triggering model-convergent violations, type-aware auditing and externalized detection are critical for policy-governed deployments.

Limitations

Scope. We evaluate seven API-accessible models from six providers (Appendix E); smaller open-source models (7B–70B) may exhibit different vulnerability patterns. τ^2-bench covers retail and airline customer service only—effects in other domains remain untested, though within-study cross-domain consistency is encouraging. Our matched-pair design requires synthetic ambiguity construction, which may not capture the full distribution of naturally occurring ambiguities; realism validation (§4) confirms lexical comparability but cannot rule out distributional gaps.

Measurement. Each model is evaluated by a single cross-judge, confounding judge identity with model identity; within-judge-group analyses confirm C1 individually (both $p < 0.001$) but not C3 (Appendix P), and cross-model type ranking concordance is only moderate (Appendix M). Per-type reliability varies—authorization scope has the lowest agreement ($\kappa = 0.385$) and per-type

human–LLM estimates rest on small cell sizes with wide confidence intervals (Appendix G)—while failure mode coding achieves moderate agreement ($\kappa = 0.52$), with minority categories less reliable.

Confounds. Incompleteness resolution necessarily adds policy content, creating an information asymmetry; our logistic regression controls and coreferential lower-bound analysis mitigate but do not eliminate this confound (§5). Our primary analysis uses a moderate-or-above severity threshold; switching to any-violation yields consistent results, with all four claims remaining significant and concordant type rankings.

Data and Code Availability

The 300 clause pairs, evaluation pipeline, analysis scripts, and raw episode traces will be released upon publication at `https://github.com/anonymous/policy-ambiguity-safety`.

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A TOST Equivalence Sensitivity

Table 3 reports the TOST equivalence analysis (Lakens, 2017) across seven margins. Three pairs involving incompleteness never reach equivalence even at ± 20 pp: conditional precedence–incompleteness ($\Delta = 16.8$ pp), coreferential–incompleteness ($\Delta = 22.0$ pp), and incompleteness–scopal ($\Delta = 14.2$ pp).

B Mitigation Experiment

Table 4 reports the per-type, per-model Δpp from the disambiguation-instruction mitigation experiment (1,256 treatment episodes across five of six types; coreferential was not tested). Coreferential pairs are excluded from both the mitigation and

Table 3: TOST equivalence sensitivity across margins. Mid-tier = fraction of the six within-cluster pairs (lexical, auth. scope, scopal, cond. prec.) that are equivalent. Inc. and Cor. columns indicate separation from the mid-tier cluster.

Margin	Equiv. pairs	Mid-tier	Inc. sep.	Cor. sep.
±5 pp	0/15	0/6	✓	✓
±8 pp	0/15	0/6	✓	✓
±10 pp	3/15	3/6	✓	✓
±12 pp	5/15	5/6	✓	✓
±15 pp	8/15	6/6	✓	–
±18 pp	9/15	6/6	✓	–
±20 pp	12/15	6/6	–	–

replication experiments. In mitigation, their ambiguous and unambiguous variants differ only in pronoun resolution, making it impossible to craft targeted disambiguation instructions without revealing the experimental manipulation. In replication, the τ^2-bench episode design for coreferential ambiguity is tightly coupled to the original five-model configuration; extending it to new model families would require redesigning the episode templates, which falls outside the scope of this confirmatory replication. The treatment appends a type-specific disambiguation instruction to the agent's system prompt. Control rates are the matched 5-type subset from the full study (§5).

C Severity Threshold Comparison

Table 5 compares all four claims under two violation severity thresholds. The primary analysis uses moderate-or-above; the alternative includes 198 additional minor violations (6.6% of episodes).

D Ambiguity Type Detection Experiment

To assess whether our taxonomy supports automated identification, we conduct a proof-of-concept detection experiment using GPT-4.1 as a zero-shot classifier. Given a policy clause, the classifier determines (1) whether it contains ambiguity and (2) the specific type from a five-type subset of our taxonomy. Coreferential ambiguity is excluded because its variants are lexically identical to their unambiguous counterparts, making surface-level type detection inapplicable.

We evaluate on 500 policy clauses (250 ambiguous, 250 unambiguous) using stratified 5-fold cross-validation, with clause pairs kept in the same fold to prevent leakage. Table 6 reports per-type results.

Detection difficulty is inversely correlated with agent vulnerability: incompleteness, the most dangerous type (53.6% violation rate, §5), is the hardest to detect (F1 = 0.34), while conditional precedence (36.8% violation rate) is the easiest (F1 = 0.94). This asymmetry arises because types with overt linguistic signals (e.g., conditional structures) are readily detectable but only moderately dangerous, whereas missing information leaves no surface trace for a classifier to exploit.

The primary confusion pathway is authorization scope → lexical (48% of authorization scope clauses): authorization boundary clauses frequently contain polysemous terms, causing the classifier to attribute the ambiguity to word-level rather than permission-level underspecification.

These results position automated detection as a viable first-pass screening tool (binary F1 = 0.81) but an unreliable type classifier, particularly for the highest-risk types. The classifier was evaluated on synthetic clauses derived from τ^2-bench; generalization to naturally occurring policy documents requires further validation.

E Replication on Additional Model Families

To test cross-architecture generalization beyond the five main-study models, we replicate the core analyses on two additional model families: Gemini-2.5-Flash (Google) and LLaMA-4-Scout (Meta), each with 250 clause pairs × 2 conditions = 500 episodes judged by GPT-5.4. These models represent two additional providers not in the original study. We exclude coreferential ambiguity because its disambiguation relies on benchmark-specific assertion structure rather than clause-level text changes (§3), limiting cross-benchmark generalizability. Tables 7 and 8 report the results.

C1 replication. Both models show significant binary ambiguity effects (Gemini $\Delta = +33.6$ pp, OR $= 14.5$, $p < 10^{-21}$; LLaMA $\Delta = +20.0$ pp, OR $= 2.8$, $p < 10^{-6}$), extending C1 to seven models across six providers. Gemini's effect size falls within the original five-model range (+25.7 to +39.0 pp). LLaMA's smaller effect and lower OR are attributable to an elevated unambiguous baseline (17.6% vs. <10% for all other models), suggesting weaker baseline instruction following that compresses the ambiguity-specific delta. LLaMA 3.3's elevated unambiguous baseline (17.6% vs. 7.3–12.7% for main-study models) likely reflects weaker baseline instruction following, suggesting that absolute violation rates are model-dependent

Table 4: Violation rate change (Δpp) after adding type-specific disambiguation instructions. Negative values indicate reduction. Baseline violation rates are shown in parentheses. Coreferential was excluded because it was not included in the mitigation experiment.

Type	GPT-5.4	GPT-4.1	Claude	Qwen3	DeepSeek	Pooled
Auth. scope	−40.0 (64)	−26.0 (46)	0.0 (12)	−14.0 (26)	−10.0 (60)	−18.0 (42)
Lexical	−16.5 (42)	−10.0 (34)	−8.0 (32)	−8.0 (52)	−2.0 (54)	−8.9 (43)
Cond. prec.	−4.6 (34)	−10.0 (36)	−12.0 (36)	−2.0 (40)	−12.0 (38)	−8.1 (37)
Scopal	−6.7 (42)	−4.0 (38)	−10.0 (32)	−2.7 (37)	+2.0 (48)	−4.3 (39)
Incomp.	−2.6 (46)	−14.0 (58)	−2.0 (48)	−2.0 (62)	+4.0 (54)	−3.4 (54)
Overall	−14.0 (46)	−12.8 (42)	−6.4 (32)	−5.8 (43)	−3.6 (51)	−8.5 (43)

Table 5: Claim-level comparison under two severity thresholds.

Claim	Moderate+	Any-violation	Concordance
C1 Δ	34.0 pp	38.2 pp	Both $p < 10^{-50}$
C2 V	0.137	0.169	Both $p < 10^{-4}$
C3 Δ	6.1 pp	7.4 pp	Both $p < 0.02$
C4 V	0.102	0.097	Both $p < 10^{-5}$
Type ranking		Kendall $\tau = 0.73$, $p = 0.056$	

Table 6: Proof-of-concept detection classifier (GPT-4.1, zero-shot, 5-fold CV). Binary ambiguity detection: F1 = 0.81, FPR = 4.4%. Six-class macro F1 = 0.63.

Type	Prec.	Recall	F1
Cond. precedence	0.96	0.92	0.94
Scopal	0.91	0.64	0.75
Auth. scope	1.00	0.36	0.53
Lexical	0.36	0.42	0.39
Incompleteness	0.48	0.26	0.34
No ambiguity	0.76	0.96	0.85

Table 7: Replication results on two additional model families. C2 rank ρ is computed against the original five-model pooled type ranking.

Model	Amb. (%)	Unamb. (%)	Δpp	p	C2 ρ
Gemini-2.5-Flash	37.6	4.0	+33.6	$< 10^{-21}$	0.60
LLaMA-4-Scout	37.6	17.6	+20.0	$< 10^{-6}$	0.90*

Table 8: Per-type ambiguous violation rates (%) for replication models vs. original five-model pooled rates.

Type	Gemini	LLaMA	Orig. pooled
Incompleteness	48	52	53.6
Lexical	50	38	42.8
Auth. scope	22	40	41.6
Scopal	34	30	39.4
Cond. prec.	34	28	36.8

even absent ambiguity.

C2 replication. Both models' type rankings correlate positively with the original pooled ranking. LLaMA shows a strong and significant correlation ($\rho = 0.90$, $p = 0.037$), with incompleteness as the top type and the bottom three types matching the reference order exactly. Gemini shows a moderate positive correlation ($\rho = 0.60$, $p = 0.285$), with the top two types (lexical and incompleteness) swapped relative to the reference. Incompleteness remains ≥46% in all seven models (range: 46–62%), confirming its status as a consistent vulnerability independent of architecture or provider. *Significant at $\alpha = 0.05$.

F Incompleteness Confound Analysis

Incompleteness is structurally distinct from the other five types: its unambiguous variant necessarily adds policy content (specifying what was previously missing) rather than merely resolving an existing ambiguity. This raises a confound: the 49.2 pp effect may partly reflect the information addition rather than ambiguity resolution per se.

A logistic regression controlling for per-clause information delta (token count difference between ambiguous and unambiguous variants) confirms that incompleteness remains individually significant ($p = 0.022$, coefficient change $< 8\%$ relative to the uncontrolled model). Coreferential ambiguity, whose variants are lexically identical (information delta $= 0$), provides a confound-free lower bound: its 31.6% violation rate and 18.7 pp effect are entirely attributable to semantic ambiguity. Token count is a coarse proxy for information content; finer-grained semantic measures (e.g., propositional content analysis) may reveal different confound structures.

Per-type token deltas between unambiguous and ambiguous variants range from 17.5 words (conditional precedence) to 36.1 words (authorization scope). Notably, authorization scope has the largest delta (36.1) yet lower violation rates than incompleteness (delta 34.6), providing counter-evidence against a pure information-quantity explanation: if

token delta drove violations, authorization scope should exceed incompleteness. Coreferential pairs have zero token delta (lexically identical variants), providing a confound-free baseline.

Excluding incompleteness entirely, the pooled ambiguity effect remains large and significant ($\Delta = 31.0$ pp, OR $= 7.75$, $p < 10^{-75}$), confirming that C1 does not depend on any single type.

Excluding incompleteness, the remaining five types show a non-significant omnibus difference (χ^2, $p = 0.079$), but pairwise contrasts with Holm–Bonferroni correction reveal a two-tier pattern: authorization scope ($p_{\text{adj}} = 0.039$) and lexical ($p_{\text{adj}} = 0.025$) remain significantly above coreferential, while the four remaining pairs are equivalent at the ± 15 pp margin.

G Per-Type Judge Reliability

Table 9 reports per-type human–LLM binary agreement (κ) on the 100-episode stratified sample (200 human–LLM rating pairs: two annotators $\times$ corresponding LLM judge). Per-type samples range from 32 to 34 episodes, yielding wide confidence intervals.

Table 9: Per-type human–LLM binary agreement (moderate-or-above threshold). CI: bootstrap 95% confidence interval.

Type	n	κ	95% CI
Lexical	32	0.904	[0.64, 1.00]
Cond. precedence	34	0.837	[0.53, 1.00]
Incompleteness	34	0.795	[0.56, 1.00]
Auth. scope	34	0.644	[0.35, 0.91]
Scopal	32	0.636	[0.00, 1.00]
Coreferential	34	0.479	[0.00, 0.84]
Overall (pooled)	200	0.735	[0.62, 0.85]

Authorization scope has the lowest human–LLM κ among the four substantively high-rate types (0.644), consistent with its lowest cross-judge κ (0.385, §4). Both reflect the inherent difficulty of permission-boundary judgments rather than systematic judge failure: raw agreement is still 85.3%, and the 52 pp within-judge model range (§5.4) far exceeds measurement noise. Coreferential's low κ (0.479) reflects the prevalence paradox—its violation base rate is 8.8%, compressing the κ denominator despite 85.3% raw agreement. Per-type estimates are imprecise due to small cell sizes ($n = 32$–34); type-level ranking should not be over-interpreted.

H Information Delta Logistic Regression

Table 10 reports the full logistic regression controlling for token-count difference between ambiguous and unambiguous variants (information delta). The reference category is authorization scope (type) and Claude Sonnet 4.6 (model). Token delta is significant ($p < 0.001$) but small in magnitude (OR $= 1.022$ per token), indicating that information quantity partially confounds the type effect. Critically, incompleteness remains individually significant ($p = 0.018$) after controlling for token delta, with a coefficient change of $<8\%$ relative to the model without the covariate. The slightly lower p-value compared to the univariate confound control in Appendix F ($p = 0.022$) reflects the additional variance absorbed by model covariates in the full specification.

Table 10: Logistic regression predicting violation (moderate+). Reference: authorization scope, Claude Sonnet 4.6. $N = 2{,}997$, pseudo-$R^2 = 0.175$.

Predictor	Coef.	SE	z	p
Intercept	-3.914	0.298	-13.12	$< 10^{-4}$
Condition (amb.)	2.278	0.116	19.65	$< 10^{-4}$
Token delta	0.022	0.006	3.49	< 0.001
Cond. prec.	0.251	0.202	1.24	0.215
Coreferential	0.528	0.244	2.17	0.030
Incompleteness	0.379	0.161	2.36	0.018
Lexical	0.336	0.176	1.91	0.056
Scopal	0.311	0.202	1.54	0.123
DeepSeek-V3	0.854	0.153	5.59	$< 10^{-4}$
GPT-4.1	0.423	0.156	2.71	0.007
GPT-5.4	0.321	0.158	2.04	0.042
Qwen3-235B	0.656	0.154	4.25	$< 10^{-4}$

I Bootstrap Cluster Analysis

To complement the margin-dependent TOST analysis, we apply Ward's hierarchical clustering to the six observed type-level violation rates, bootstrapped $B = 10{,}000$ times by resampling clause pairs within each type. At $k = 2$, incompleteness (53.6%) forms a singleton cluster, with the remaining five types (31.6–42.8%) in the second cluster, reproducing in 34.3% of bootstrap samples—the most frequent partition but not overwhelmingly stable, reflecting that the 10.8 pp gap between incompleteness and lexical is moderate relative to within-type variance. At $k = 3$, coreferential (31.6%) additionally separates, consistent with the TOST two-tier structure. The AU p-value for the incompleteness singleton is 0.47, confirming that while the singleton is the modal partition, the boundary

is not sharp.

J Clause-Level Variance

Leave-one-out analysis confirms that no single clause drives any type-level rate: maximum LOO shift is 1.4 pp (coreferential), and all types have LOO ranges $\leq$2.1 pp. Within-type coefficients of variation (CV) range from 0.69 (incompleteness) to 1.03 (coreferential), confirming high clause-level heterogeneity. This heterogeneity is expected—clause wording determines the specific ambiguity instance—and is controlled by the matched-pair design, which compares each clause's ambiguous and unambiguous variants rather than relying on type-level means.

K Multiple Comparison Correction

We apply Holm–Bonferroni correction within three test families: (i) per-type$\times$model McNemar tests for C1 (30 tests), (ii) TOST pairwise equivalence for C2 (15 pairs), and (iii) model$\times$type interaction for C4 (1 omnibus + post-hoc).

L DRIP-R Category Mapping

DRIP-R's five RE ambiguity categories—attachment, coordination, anaphora, scope, and ellipsis—overlap partially with our six-type taxonomy: scopal ambiguity and coreferential ambiguity correspond directly, while our remaining four types (lexical, authorization scope, incompleteness, conditional precedence) address policy-specific phenomena outside DRIP-R's RE scope.

M Cross-Model Type Ranking Concordance

To quantify agreement among models on the relative difficulty of ambiguity types, we compute Kendall's coefficient of concordance W. For the five main-study models across all six types, $W = 0.398$ ($\chi^2(5) = 9.94$, $p = 0.072$), indicating moderate but non-significant concordance. Including the two replication models (Gemini 2.5 Flash and LLaMA 4 Scout) over five shared types (excluding coreferential, which was not included in replication), concordance reaches significance: $W = 0.353$ ($\chi^2(4) = 9.89$, $p = 0.038$). In both analyses, incompleteness consistently ranks highest (mean rank 5.5 / 4.5), while coreferential (2.0, five-model only) and conditional precedence (2.8 / 2.1) rank lowest, supporting the two-tier structure identified in §5.

N C4 Interaction Without Authorization Scope

Excluding authorization scope, the residual model$\times$type interaction vanishes ($\chi^2(16) = 7.13$, $p = 0.97$; logistic regression LR test: $\chi^2(16) = 9.22$, $p = 0.90$), confirming that the C4 interaction is driven entirely by authorization scope—the type most plausibly targeted by differential safety training.

O Per-Type Clause Length Analysis

Unambiguous clauses are systematically longer than their ambiguous counterparts across all types (Table 11), reflecting the additional specification needed for disambiguation. Authorization scope (+36.1 words) and incompleteness (+34.6 words) show the largest deltas, consistent with the observation that resolving these types requires substantial additional content. Notably, authorization scope has the largest delta (+36.1) yet lower violation rates than incompleteness (+34.6 delta), providing counter-evidence against a pure information-quantity explanation of incompleteness's upper-bound status. The confound analysis in Appendix F controls for this length asymmetry.

Type	Amb. (mean $\pm$ SD)	Unamb. (mean $\pm$ SD)	Δ
auth_scope	19.0 ± 3.3	55.0 ± 8.1	+36.1
incompleteness	12.2 ± 2.4	46.8 ± 9.1	+34.6
lexical	11.4 ± 2.3	37.0 ± 5.8	+25.7
scopal	15.7 ± 3.0	33.5 ± 8.5	+17.8
cond_prec	41.1 ± 7.0	58.6 ± 8.6	+17.5

Table 11: Per-type clause length (words). Coreferential excluded (identical surface forms).

P Within-Judge-Group Type Rankings

Type rankings show near-zero correlation across judge groups (Spearman $\rho = -0.03$, $p = 0.96$). This is driven by authorization scope's rank reversal (rank 1 in GPT-4.1-judged group vs. rank 6 in GPT-5.4-judged group), which reflects agent composition: the GPT-4.1-judged group contains the two agents most vulnerable to authorization scope (DeepSeek 60%, GPT-5.4 64%), while the GPT-5.4-judged group contains the least vulnerable (Claude 12%). Incompleteness ranks 1–2 in both groups, supporting its stability independent of judge identity. This finding further motivates treating authorization scope results with caution (§8).

Q Binary Effect Excluding Incompleteness

Excluding incompleteness—the highest-violation type—the pooled ambiguous violation rate remains significantly elevated (38.4% vs. 7.5% unambiguous; $\Delta = 31.0\,\text{pp}$, OR $= 7.75$, $\chi^2 = 338.8$, $p < 10^{-75}$). The binary ambiguity effect (C1) is therefore not driven by incompleteness alone.